

The University Times

To Raise Income for Infrastructure, Trinity Considers Student Levy

Dominic McGrath
DEPUTY EDITOR

A new levy on students to contribute to the cost of Trinity's infrastructure is currently being considered by College, *The University Times* has learned, as part of a "radical" approach to fundraising. In a document submitted to Trinity's Finance Committee on October 26th, the committee members were asked to consider the possible introduction of an annual student infrastructure contribution for undergraduate students. The document, which was sub-

mitted to the committee by Trinity's Chief Financial Officer, Ian Mathews, contains a number of "income generation strategies" to raise funds for Trinity relating to a number of areas, including the Commercial Revenue Unit, Trinity's Global Relations Strategy and undergraduate fee levels. During discussions of the levy, the committee asked Mathews to explore the option of a levy on students to help fund the cost of maintaining Trinity's infrastructure. The document notes that the Finance Committee instructed Trinity's Director of Public Affairs and Communication, Tom Molloy, to look at how the university might "communicate the message that Trinity has unique

needs due to the distinguishing factors of a Trinity education". College's Financial Services Division was also asked to develop a number of models looking at how much various levy amounts might impact on Trinity's income. Infrastructure costs, which are one of the largest costs Trinity faces annually due to its age, are currently not covered by the Higher Education Authority (HEA). Any additional contribution would raise fees for students studying in Trinity above those in other colleges and universities across Ireland. Students who qualify for free fees currently pay €3,000 in the student contribution fee, which is set by the government, as well as the €120

Sports Centre levy and €8 Union of Students in Ireland (USI) levy. In an email statement to *The University Times*, Mathews acknowledged that the Finance Committee, which is chaired by Provost Patrick Prendergast, had asked him to "explore" an annual student levy. Mathews declined to give any indication of the size of such a levy: "I'm sure you can understand it would be premature for me to speculate on whether this concept might see the light of day and what the size of any potential contribution might be." Mathews noted that, at a meeting of Finance Committee on No-

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Halls Accommodation Project "Deprioritised", with Other Campus Sites Explored

Brónagh Kennedy
STAFF WRITER

A planned accommodation project in Trinity Hall that would have seen 300 to 400 beds built on the site has been "deprioritised". College is, however, exploring possible accommodation projects at Grand Canal Dock and Santry. The project at Trinity Hall in Dartry would have seen Cunningham House, which was built in the 1970s, replaced with a more modern accommodation complex. Trinity is currently awaiting planning permission for the Oisín House accommodation project, which, if approved, would allow construction to begin on the project, delivering 250 beds for Trinity students, with construction ending in 2019 at the earliest. Geraldine Ruane, Trinity's Chief Operating Officer, speaking to *The University Times*, said that "Dartry got pushed down the ranking order". Ruane continued, saying this is an issue that must be addressed as "it is critical that we get the student accommodation, but we have only so much bandwidth to do all these projects". College is turning its attention to potential sites in Trinity's Technology and Enterprise Campus (TEEC) in Grand Canal Dock while accommodation at Santry is also a "possibility", according to Prendergast. Ruane said that, as part of the development of its

that College is "going through one of the largest development phases in recent history, and we have to recognise that we can't do everything". Trinity was advertising in September for a project manager for an accommodation project in Trinity Hall. "They never questioned the financial viability of it or its benefit to College, but when you've got too many projects on the table, and you have to prioritise, this one just fell down the rankings", O'Kelly added. Trinity is currently awaiting planning permission for the Oisín House accommodation project, which, if approved, would allow construction to begin on the project, delivering 250 beds for Trinity students, with construction ending in 2019 at the earliest. Ruane warned, however, that there is no indication that more student accommodation will result in lower rent: "For the next five years, you can expect the price to go only one way, and price centrally is going up." "I am determined to push for this, but I am not at war with College", O'Kelly stated about Trinity Hall. "Sometime in the near future, there will be another prioritisation exercise, which they are continuously doing, and hopefully this will go up the ladder."

Estates Strategy, College could examine a possible 500 beds in TTEC or 300 beds in Santry. O'Kelly recognised a longstanding view that "what we should focus on is the primary role of College, which is education. And with diverting resources to accommodation, there's always a debate in terms of space and money in relation to that". O'Kelly stressed, however, the importance of providing accommodation as schools grow, both for attracting international students, where providing accommodation as "part of the package" is attractive, but also students within Ireland. Students, he said, will be "very wary and think twice about coming to a city centre university without some confidence of accommodation. It's become part of the academic mission of College, rather than something nice we used to do if we could". Ruane warned, however, that there is no indication that more student accommodation will result in lower rent: "For the next five years, you can expect the price to go only one way, and price centrally is going up." "I am determined to push for this, but I am not at war with College", O'Kelly stated about Trinity Hall. "Sometime in the near future, there will be another prioritisation exercise, which they are continuously doing, and hopefully this will go up the ladder."

It's Beginning to Look a Lot Like Trinity



PHOTO BY ANNA MORAN FOR THE UNIVERSITY TIMES

Trinity's Open Day Prospective students explored a festive campus on Saturday morning for Trinity's Open Day. Met by event guides and prospectuses at every entrance, future students and their parents saw what Trinity had to offer through stalls, demonstrations and tours.

Proposals to Halve Erasmus Funding Will Prove Unpopular

Simon Foy outlines how suggested cuts to the Erasmus programme's budget would be a regressive step that would alienate young people [PAGE 15»](#)



A World Champion in Taekwondo in Our Midst

Donal MacNamee sits down with first-year European studies student Ellen Ince, who is taking Taekwondo to new and more public heights in Ireland [PAGE 20»](#)



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38% of Trinity Staff on Temporary Contracts

John Conway
ASSISTANT NEWS EDITOR

Thirty-eight per cent of Trinity staff are employed on temporary contracts, with academic staff making up 40 per cent of the temporary staff employed by Trinity, according to figures in a new report seen by *The University Times*. According to a report submitted to College Board in October the number of temporary staff employed by Trinity has increased from what was 32 per cent in the 2006 academic year. The report, "Gender and Trinity Staff: Trends in Contract Types", also reveals that approximately one-fifth of staff in Trinity are part time - including staff who work less than the standard number of full-time hours through job-sharing arrangements or sim-

ply because they cannot get enough hours to be considered full time. Temporary staff refers to staff members who are employed on either fixed-term or specific purpose contracts. A fixed-term contract is one where the end date of the contract is specified from the outset, whereas a specific purpose contract is a contract that will terminate in the case of a certain event or purpose being fulfilled, such as until funding for a project runs out or to cover for someone who is away on indefinite leave. The report also found that, according to working-time equivalent data, which counts two or more part-time staff members completing full-time hours per week between them as one member of staff, 63 per cent of non-academic staff are employed on temporary contracts.

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Education Committee Members Challenge Fine Gael Position on Funding

Dominic McGrath
DEPUTY EDITOR

The Minister for Education and Skills, Richard Bruton's, desire for "consensus" on a new funding model for higher education has been challenged by a number of Oireachtas Education and Skills Committee members. Carol Nolan TD, Sinn Féin's spokesperson for education and skills, who sits on the Education and Skills Committee, has criticised Fine Gael and the party's position on a new higher education funding model. Bruton and his party have remained silent on their preference for a new funding model since the publication of the report of the government's higher education funding working group in July, which puts forward three options for higher education funding. Speaking to *The University Times*, Nolan has ac-

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